European Overview

Not just sunshine and rainbows

We see European credit spreads creeping wider in 2026, outperforming the US as a benign macro backdrop meets weakening technicals. Yields will still anchor demand, for positive total returns across markets. We summarise main points of disagreements from outlook meetings so far with clients.

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To prepare the ground for 2026, we summarise our views across European credit markets in the first Alpha of the year.

At a big picture level, we expect the global macro backdrop to remain benign in 2026, with technicals still strong in Europe, as yield-driven demand extends amid a largely unchanged supply pipeline. But deteriorating technicals stemming from the US (principally supply-led), and tight starting valuations will likely cause credit spreads to creep wider over 2026, with Europe outperforming the US in spread terms. With all-in yields still high, we still expect respectable total returns across markets.

One of the benefits of writing a comprehensive outlook is the thought-provoking conversations it initiates with investors of all types. Below, we outline five topics where there appears to be general disagreement – between our views and that of investors, or where there is little – or very strong – investor consensus:

1. **Supremacy of technicals.** A key part of our view of slightly wider spreads in 2026 is predicated on US supply technicals acting as a headwind. Investor sympathy for this view is mixed: either investors acknowledge this is a risk, or they disagree; they see demand strong enough to mitigate the increased supply; or they do not see supply/demand technicals as a long-term driver of credit spread valuations. This makes investors in general either in line with our view, or more bullish on performance in 2026.

1. **US versus Europe.** Although likely a bias in the European client base we have met, most investors agree with our preference for European credit over the US. One counterpoint to this is the projected change in 3mth hedging costs between the US and Europe (Figure 1), which will benefit the US over Europe for yield-focussed investors. For some investors, this is a reason to be wary of being overweight €-HY (in particular), while this is seen as a reason to support a preference for $-HY. US versus Europe also comes up in valuation of reverse Yankees in the context of the potential for more reverse Yankee supply. This makes us cautious on reverse Yankees at current valuations, while a fair few investors still like US issuers, even inside European spreads.

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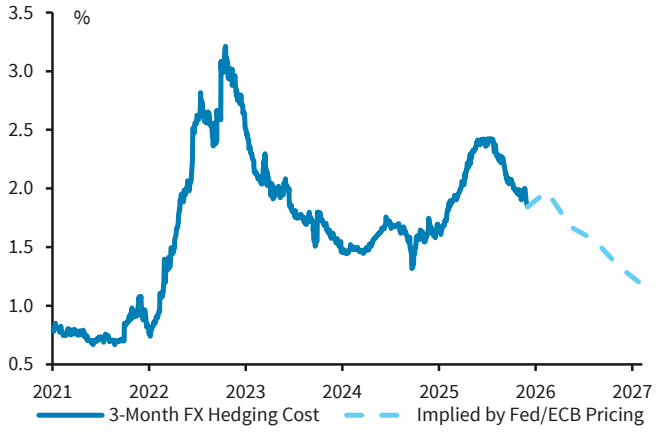
2. **Sector views.** We are Market Weight European IG Banks, as strong fundamentals are balanced against tight valuations – versus non-financials, as well as covered bonds. We receive general pushback against this view, with banks still in favour by many investors. In particular, the prospects of increased reverse Yankee supply in non-financials is seen as driver to support continued outperformance. Equally, the much stronger fundamentals, and profitability, makes many investors consider history as a poor guide to how banks could trade going forward.

3. **Best carry.** We consider the best sources of carry through the lens of 'Liberation Day' downside, for a given amount of return in unchanged markets. Here, B-rated credit and corporate hybrid screen better than IG seniors and AT1s, which tends to spark a lively discussion. There is general sympathy for corporate hybrids being a good place to generate carry, versus potential downsides, while our view of AT1 being much riskier is met with general disagreement.

4. **Private credit risk.** This topic came up often, but with no one convinced of any meaningful downside to public markets in 2026, owing to low leverage making forced selling unlikely. We did get some challenges to our Overweight on the Insurance sector, due to private credit exposures. Within public markets, we did get some raised eyebrows over the observation that the European leveraged loan market having sizeable 2028 maturity wall (Figure 2), which could make that market more vulnerable to a sudden (and persistent) deterioration in market sentiment.

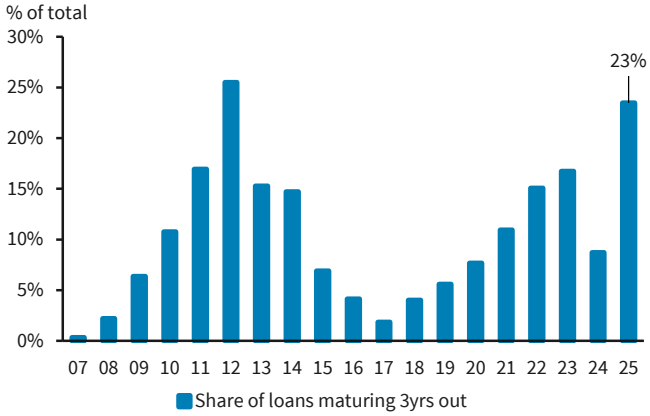
FIGURE 1. 3mth FX hedging costs from USD into EUR is projected to decline meaningfully if the priced rate path prevails



FXHCEUUS ticker, and projected cost based on rate path of Fed and ECB from WIRP.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. The 2028 leveraged loan maturity wall is formidable, the highest as a percentage of the market since 2012



Loans in ELLI maturing three years out in percent of market size, for each year historically.
Source: PitchBook, Barclays Research

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